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INTERLOCKING ANDIRON SYSTEMS AND RELATED METHODS

Abstract

A representative andiron system includes: a first firedog exhibiting a rectangular transverse cross-section with a height dimension being at least three times longer than a width dimension, and a first front post; a front upper finger and a front lower finger, each extending from the first firedog; the first firedog, the front upper finger, and the front lower finger being formed of contiguous material and exhibiting a planar configuration, the first front post being formed of contiguous material and exhibiting a planar configuration; the first front post having a first upper opening and a first lower opening; in a first assembled configuration, the front upper finger extends through the first upper opening and the front lower finger extends through the first lower opening.

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Background/Summary

BACKGROUND

Technical Field

[0001] The disclosure generally relates to andirons for use with combustible material.

Description of the Related Art

[0002] Andirons have been documented to 3 AD to elevate combustible materials (wood, for example) to enhance combustion. Andirons are the correct tool for firewood combustion. Andiron production also tends to be labor intensive owing to traditional manufacturing techniques such as forging and/or welding. Additionally, assembled andirons are bulky, resulting in logistics challenges and corresponding increases in shipping costs due to packaging constraints. As an example, conventional andirons formed of cast iron tend to be quite heavy and brittle, which may implicate significant shipping costs due to the weight as well as the amount of protective packaging (foam, for example) required.

SUMMARY

[0003] In this regard, interlocking andiron systems and related methods are provided. An example embodiment of an interlocking andiron system for use with combustible material, comprises: a first andiron assembly having a first firedog and a first front post; the first firedog having a body extending in a longitudinal direction from a proximal end to a distal end and being configured to support the combustible material in an elevated position, the first firedog exhibiting a rectangular transverse cross-section with a height dimension being at least three times longer than a width dimension, the distal end of the first firedog having a front vertical contact face; a front upper finger and a front lower finger, each extending from the front vertical contact face of the first firedog, the front upper finger having an outwardly extending front upper segment and terminating in a downwardly extending front upper tip, the front upper segment having a bottom horizontal contact surface, the front upper tip having an inwardly facing vertical contact surface, the front lower finger having an outwardly extending front lower segment and terminating in a downwardly extending front lower tip, the front lower segment having a bottom horizontal contact surface, the front lower tip having an inwardly facing vertical contact surface; the first firedog, the front upper finger, and the front lower finger being formed of contiguous material and exhibiting a planar configuration, the first front post being formed of contiguous material and exhibiting a planar configuration; the first front post having an inward face, an outward face opposing the inward face, a first upper aperture, and a first lower aperture, the first upper aperture defining a first upper opening extending through the first front post from the inward face to the outward face and being aligned to receive the front upper finger, the first lower aperture defining a first lower opening extending through the first front post from the inward face to the outward face and being aligned to receive the front lower finger, the first upper aperture having a lower horizontal contact surface, the first lower aperture having a lower horizontal contact surface; in a first assembled configuration, in which the first front post is disposed in a vertical orientation and the body of the first firedog is disposed in a horizontal orientation, the front upper finger extends through the first upper opening with the front upper tip being disposed adjacent the outward face of the first front post, the front lower finger extends through the first lower opening with the front lower tip being disposed adjacent the outward face of the first front post, the bottom horizontal contact surface of the front upper segment engages the lower horizontal contact surface of the first upper aperture, and the bottom horizontal contact surface of the front lower segment engages the lower horizontal contact surface of the first lower aperture.

[0004] An example embodiment of a method for providing an andiron system comprises: providing a sheet of steel plate; forming, as a contiguous non-weld first workpiece, a first firedog, a front upper finger, and a front lower finger from the sheet of steel plate; and forming, as a contiguous non-weld second workpiece, a first front post.

[0005] Another example embodiment of a method for providing an andiron system comprises:

providing a sheet of steel plate; forming, as a contiguous non-weld first workpiece, a first firedog, a front upper finger, and a front lower finger from the sheet of steel plate; and forming, as a contiguous non-weld second workpiece, a first front post; wherein: the first firedog has a body extending in a longitudinal direction from a proximal end to a distal end and being configured to support the combustible material in an elevated position, the first firedog exhibiting a rectangular transverse cross-section with a height dimension being at least three times longer than a width dimension, the distal end of the first firedog having a front vertical contact face; the front upper finger and the front lower finger each extend from the front vertical contact face of the first firedog, the front upper finger having an outwardly extending front upper segment and terminating in a downwardly extending front upper tip, the front upper segment having a bottom horizontal contact surface, the front upper tip having an inwardly facing vertical contact surface, the front lower finger having an outwardly extending front lower segment and terminating in a downwardly extending front lower tip, the front lower segment having a bottom horizontal contact surface, the front lower tip having an inwardly facing vertical contact surface; the first front post has an inward face, an outward face opposing the inward face, a first upper aperture, and a first lower aperture, the first upper aperture defining a first upper opening extending through the first front post from the inward face to the outward face and being aligned to receive the front upper finger, the first lower aperture defining a first lower opening extending through the first front post from the inward face to the outward face and being aligned to receive the front lower finger, the first upper aperture having a lower horizontal contact surface, the first lower aperture having a lower horizontal contact surface; in a first assembled configuration, in which the first front post is disposed in a vertical orientation and the body of the first firedog is disposed in a horizontal orientation, the front upper finger extends through the first upper opening with the front upper tip being disposed adjacent the outward face of the first front post, the front lower finger extends through the first lower opening with the front lower tip being disposed adjacent the outward face of the first front post, the bottom horizontal contact surface of the front upper segment engages the lower horizontal contact surface of the first upper aperture, and the bottom horizontal contact surface of the front lower segment engages the lower horizontal contact surface of the first lower aperture.
[0006] Other objects, features, and/or advantages will become apparent from the following detailed description of the preferred but non-limiting embodiments. The following description is made with reference to the accompanying drawings.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS
[0007] Non-limiting and non-exhaustive embodiments are described with reference to the following drawings. In the drawings, like reference numerals refer to like parts throughout the various figures unless otherwise specified. These drawings are not necessarily drawn to scale. Likewise, the relative sizes of elements illustrated by the drawings may differ from the relative sizes depicted.
[0008] The disclosure can be more fully understood by the subsequent detailed description and examples with reference made to the accompanying drawings.
[0009] FIG. **1** is a schematic diagram of an exemplary embodiment of an andiron system.
[0010] FIG. **2**A is a schematic diagram of the exemplary embodiment of a firedog from FIG. **1**.
[0011] FIG. **2**B is a cross-section of the embodiment of the firedog of FIG. **2**A as viewed along section line **2**B-**2**B.
[0012] FIG. **3**A is a schematic diagram of the exemplary embodiment of a front post from FIG. **1**.
[0013] FIG. **3**B is a cross-section of the embodiment of the post of FIG. **3**A as viewed along section line **3**B-**3**B.

[0014] FIG. **4** is a schematic, cross-sectional cut-away showing engagement of a firedog and corresponding front post from FIG. **1**.
[0015] FIG. **5** is a schematic, plan view of an exemplary embodiment of a sheet of material with an exemplary workpiece layout prior to separating the workpieces from the sheet material.
[0016] FIG. **6** is a schematic diagram of another exemplary embodiment of an andiron system.
[0017] FIG. **7** is a schematic diagram of another exemplary embodiment of a firedog.
[0018] FIG. **8** is a schematic diagram of another exemplary embodiment of a post.
[0019] FIG. **9** is a schematic diagram of another exemplary embodiment of an andiron system.
[0020] FIG. **10** is a schematic diagram of another exemplary embodiment of a firedog.
[0021] FIG. **11** is a schematic diagram of an exemplary embodiment of a cross member.
[0022] FIG. **12** is a flowchart depicting an exemplary embodiment of a method for providing an andiron system.
[0023] FIG. **13** is a schematic diagram of an exemplary embodiment of a firewood and andiron carrier.
[0024] FIG. **14** is a schematic diagram of embodiment of FIG. **13** in a carry configuration.
[0025] FIG. **15** is a schematic diagram of the embodiment of FIG. **13** in a stowed configuration being disposed within a flat pack for shipping.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0026] The following describes several embodiments of interlocking andiron assemblies and related methods. It is to be understood that the invention is not limited in its application to the details of the arrangements shown since the invention is capable of other embodiments. Also, the terminology used herein is for the purpose of description and not of limitation.
[0027] Reference throughout this specification to “one embodiment”, “an embodiment”, “one example”, and/or “an example” (or language similar thereto) means that a particular feature, structure, and/or characteristic described in connection with the embodiment or example is included in at least one embodiment. Thus, appearances of the phrases “in one embodiment”, “in an embodiment”, “one example”, and/or “an example” in various places throughout this specification are not necessarily all referring to the same embodiment or example. Furthermore, the feature(s), structure(s), and/or characteristic(s) may be combined in any suitable combination(s) and/or sub-combination(s) in one or more embodiments or examples.
[0028] In this regard, FIG. **1** depicts an exemplary embodiment of an interlocking andiron system **100** that includes two andiron assemblies (**102**, **104**) formed of steel. In FIG. **1**, andiron assemblies **102**, **104** are positioned side-by-side to support combustible materials **106** (e.g., firewood) in an elevated and generally horizontal (X-Z plane) orientation above a support surface (the ground or a fireplace floor, for example). Since each andiron assembly **102**, **104** incorporates similar components/features as the other, only andiron assembly **102** will be described in detail for brevity.
[0029] Andiron assembly **102** incorporates a firedog **110** and a front post **112** that are selectively interlocked to form a freestanding structure. As shown in FIG. **2**A, firedog **110** includes a body **114** that extends in a longitudinal (X axis) direction from a proximal end **116** to a distal end **118**. Firedog **110** (see, FIG. **2**B) exhibits a rectangular transverse (Z axis) cross-section with a height (Y axis) dimension (H.sub.F) being at least three times longer than a width dimension (W.sub.F). So configured, the firedog exhibits adequate structural strength to avoid sagging under an anticipated heated load, which is a common deficiency of conventional andirons. In some embodiments, the height dimension is at least four times longer than the width dimension.
[0030] Distal end **118** includes a front vertical contact face **120**. A front upper finger **122** and a front lower finger **124** extend from front vertical contact face **120**. An upper portion **121** of front vertical contact face **120** extends upwardly from front upper finger **122**, and a lower portion **123** of front vertical contact face **120** extends downwardly from front lower finger **124**.
[0031] Front upper finger **122** includes an outwardly extending front upper segment **126** with a bottom horizontal contact surface **128**. Front upper finger **122** terminates in a downwardly

extending front upper tip **130** with an inwardly facing vertical contact surface **132**. Front lower finger **124** includes an outwardly extending front lower segment **134** with a bottom horizontal contact surface **136**. Front lower finger **124** terminates in a downwardly extending front lower tip **138** with an inwardly facing vertical contact surface **140**.

[0032] A back leg **150** extends downwardly from proximal end **116**. It should be noted that various configurations of back legs (such as the depicted curved-joint configuration) may be used. In some embodiments, firedog **110**, including back leg **150**, body **114**, front upper finger **122**, and front lower finger **124** are formed of contiguous material and exhibit a planar configuration. Thus, in some embodiments, a firedog may be of uniform width along its entire length.

[0033] As shown with reference to FIGS. **3**A and **3**B, front post **112** includes an inward face **162** for facing combustible materials supported by firedog **110**, an outward face **164** that opposes inward face **162**, and a base **166**. Base **166** is shown in a two-leg configuration although various other configurations may be used in other embodiments. In some embodiments, front post **112** is formed of contiguous material and exhibits a planar configuration. Thus, in some embodiments, a front post may be of uniform width (W.sub.P) along its entire length.

[0034] A first upper aperture **170** extends through front post **112** from inward face **162** to outward face **164**. First upper aperture **170** defines a first upper opening **172** that is sized, shaped, and aligned to receive front upper finger **122**. First upper aperture **170** is rectangular and incorporates an upper horizontal contact surface **173**, a lower horizontal contact surface **175**, and side vertical contact surfaces **177**, **179**. A first lower aperture **180**, disposed lower on first post **112** than first upper aperture **170**, extends through front post **112** from inward face **162** to outward face **164**. First lower aperture **180** defines a first lower opening **182** that is sized, shaped, and aligned to receive front lower finger **124**. First lower aperture **180** is rectangular and incorporates an upper horizontal contact surface **183**, a lower horizontal contact surface **185**, and side vertical contact surfaces **187**, **189**.

[0035] With continued reference to FIG. **1**, an assembled configuration of firedog **110** and front post **112** involves front post **112** being disposed in a vertical (Y axis) orientation and body **114** of firedog **110** being disposed in a horizontal (X-Z plane) orientation. As shown in greater detail in FIG. **4**, the assembled configuration also includes front upper finger **122** extending through first upper opening **172** with front upper tip **130** being disposed adjacent outward face **164**, and front lower finger **124** extending through first lower opening **182** with front lower tip **138** being disposed adjacent outward face **164**. So arranged, bottom horizontal contact surface **128** of front upper segment **126** is aligned to engage lower horizontal contact surface **175** of first upper aperture **170**, and bottom horizontal contact surface **136** of front lower segment **134** is aligned to engage lower horizontal contact surface **185** of first lower aperture **180**. Additionally, vertical contact surfaces **132** and **140**, as well as front vertical contact face **120**, are positioned to restrict horizontal movement of firedog **110**. It should be noted that the weight of firedog **110** itself typically is adequate to bring at least one of the bottom horizontal contact surfaces into direct contact with a corresponding lower horizontal contact surface when in the assembled configuration.

[0036] In some embodiments, the components of an andiron system may be formed from one or more sheets of material without the use of welding and/or forging. By way of example, FIG. **5** depicts an exemplary sheet of material **200** (a plate of carbon steel, for example) that may be used. Sheet of material **200** is provided with an exemplary workpiece layout that includes representative andiron system components. As shown, sheet of material **200** includes a layout for workpieces **201-204**, with workpieces **201** and **203** corresponding to front post **112** and firedog **110**, respectively, and workpieces **202** and **204** corresponding to the front post and the firedog of andiron assembly **104** (see FIG. **1**).

[0037] After separating workpieces **201-204** from sheet of material **200**, each workpiece is formed of contiguous material and exhibits a uniform width along its length, which promotes efficient packaging and shipping. For instance, components may be stacked one atop another and, if desired, like components may be aligned. Protective packaging materials also may be reduced when compared to packaging materials typically required for multidimensional components that may incorporate protruding features that are prone to breakage.

[0038] FIG. **6** depicts another exemplary embodiment of an interlocking andiron system **300** that includes two andiron assemblies **302**, **402**. Andiron assemblies **302**, **402** are positioned side-by-side to support combustible materials in an elevated and generally horizontal orientation. Additionally, andiron assemblies **302**, **402** define supports for at least one horizontal cooking surface. Since each andiron assembly **302**, **402** incorporates similar components/features as the other, only andiron assembly **302** will be described in detail aside from noting that andiron assembly **402** incorporates firedogs **410**, **411**, a front post **412**, and a rear post **413**.

[0039] Andiron assembly **302** incorporates firedogs **310**, **311**, a front post **312**, and a rear post **313**. As shown in FIG. **7**, firedog **310** (which is similar to firedog **311**) includes a body **314** that extends in a longitudinal direction from a proximal end **316** to a distal end **318**. Firedog **310** exhibits a rectangular transverse cross-section with a height dimension (H.sub.F) being at least three times longer than a width dimension (W.sub.F). In some embodiments, the height dimension is at least four times longer than the width dimension.

[0040] Distal end **318** includes a front vertical contact face **320**. A front upper finger **322** and a front lower finger **324** extend from front vertical contact face **320**. An upper portion **321** of front vertical contact face **320** extends upwardly from front upper finger **322**, and a lower portion **323** of front vertical contact face **320** extends downwardly from front lower finger **324**.

[0041] Front upper finger **322** includes an outwardly extending front upper segment **326** with a bottom horizontal contact surface **328**. Front upper finger **322** terminates in a downwardly extending front upper tip **330** with an inwardly facing vertical contact surface **332**. Front lower finger **324** includes an outwardly extending front lower segment **334** with a bottom horizontal contact surface **336**. Front lower finger **324** terminates in a downwardly extending front lower tip **338** with an inwardly facing vertical contact surface **339**.

[0042] Proximal end **316** includes a back vertical contact face **340**. A back upper finger **342** and a back lower finger **344** extend from back vertical contact face **340**. An upper portion **341** of back vertical contact face **340** extends upwardly from back upper finger **342**, and a lower portion **343** of back vertical contact face **340** extends downwardly from back lower finger **344**.

[0043] Back upper finger **342** includes an outwardly extending back upper segment **346** with a bottom horizontal contact surface **348**. Back upper finger **342** terminates in a downwardly extending back upper tip **350** with an inwardly facing vertical contact surface **352**. Back lower finger **344** includes an outwardly extending back lower segment **354** with a bottom horizontal contact surface **356**. Back lower finger **344** terminates in a downwardly extending front lower tip **358** with an inwardly facing vertical contact surface **359**.

[0044] As shown in FIG. **8**, front post **312** includes an inward face **362**, an outward face **364**, and a base **366**. Base **366** is shown in a two-leg configuration although various other configurations may be used in other embodiments. In some embodiments, front post **312** is formed of contiguous material and exhibits a planar configuration. Thus, in some embodiments, a front post may be of uniform width along its entire length.

[0045] A first upper aperture **370** extends through front post **312** from inward face **162** to outward face **164**. First upper aperture **370** defines a first upper opening **372** that is sized, shaped, and aligned to receive front upper finger **322**. A first lower aperture **380**, disposed lower on first post **312** than first upper aperture **370**, extends through front post **312** from inward face **362** to outward face **364**. First lower aperture **380** defines a first lower opening **382** that is sized, shaped, and aligned to receive front lower finger **324**.

[0046] In some embodiments, multiple apertures may be formed in a post to provide optional heights at which a firedog may be installed. In the embodiment of FIG. **8**, front post **312** incorporates two additional sets of apertures. Specifically, a second upper aperture **374** and a second lower aperture **375** are disposed higher than first upper aperture **370**, and a third upper aperture **384** and a third lower aperture **385** are disposed higher than second upper aperture **374**. Each of second upper aperture **374**, second lower aperture **375**, third upper aperture **384**, and third lower aperture **385** defines a corresponding opening that is sized, shaped, and aligned to receive a corresponding finger of a firedog. It should be noted that, in the embodiment of FIG. **6**, rear post **313** incorporates components/features similar to those exhibited by front post **312**; thus, rear post **313** will not be described in detail.

[0047] Interlocking andiron system **300** (FIG. **6**) may be provided in various assembled configurations. By way of example, front and rear posts may be positioned in vertical orientations with a corresponding firedog spanning between and interconnecting a respective one of the andiron assemblies **302**, **402**. Thus, each andiron assembly may include a single firedog disposed at a desired height based on the openings through which the corresponding fingers are inserted. As such, when the firedogs are disposed at corresponding openings of the front and rear posts of both andiron assemblies, the firedogs may be used as supports for a horizontal cooking surface such as a platform, tray, or grate spanning between the firedogs.

[0048] As another example, a different assembled configuration (as shown in FIG. **6**) includes four firedogs (firedogs **310**, **311**, **410** and **411**). In particular, firedogs **310** and **311** are extend between front post **312** and rear post **313** at heights corresponding to the heights that firedogs **410** and **411** extend between front post **412** and rear post **413**. So configured, firedogs **310** and **410** may be used as supports for one horizontal cooking surface (e.g., cooking surface **390**, the location of which is shown in dashed lines and representative of one or more of various components, such as a platform, tray, and/or grate, for example). Firedogs **311** and **411** may be used as supports for another horizontal cooking surface (e.g., cooking surface **392**). Clearly, the maximum number of firedogs that may be used in forming cooking surface supports correlates with the number of openings formed through the front and rear posts.

[0049] FIG. **9** depicts another exemplary embodiment of an interlocking andiron system **500** that includes two andiron assemblies **502**, **602**. Andiron assemblies **502**, **602** are positioned side-by-side to support combustible materials in an elevated and generally horizontal orientation. Andiron system **500** also incorporates a cross member **710** that extends between and interconnects andiron assemblies **502** and **602** to maintain spacing between the respective firedogs. Since each andiron assembly **502**, **602** incorporates similar components/features as the other, only andiron assembly **502** will be described in detail aside from noting that andiron assembly **602** incorporates firedog **610** and front post **612**.

[0050] Andiron assembly **502** incorporates a firedog **510** and a front post **512**. As shown in FIG. **10**, firedog **510** includes a body **514** that extends in a longitudinal direction from a proximal end **516** to a distal end **518**. Firedog **510** exhibits a rectangular transverse cross-section with a height dimension at least three times longer than a width dimension. In some embodiments, the height dimension is at least four times longer than the width dimension.

[0051] Distal end **518** includes a front vertical contact face **520**. A front upper finger **522** and a front lower finger **524** extend from front vertical contact face **520**. An upper portion **521** of front vertical contact face **520** extends upwardly from front upper finger **522**, and a lower portion **523** of front vertical contact face **520** extends downwardly from front lower finger **524**.

[0052] Front upper finger **522** includes an outwardly extending front upper segment **526** with a bottom horizontal contact surface **528**. Front upper finger **522** terminates in a downwardly extending front upper tip **530** with an inwardly facing vertical contact surface **532**. Front lower finger **524** includes an outwardly extending front lower segment **534** with a bottom horizontal contact surface **536**. Front lower finger **524** terminates in a downwardly extending front lower tip **538** with an inwardly facing vertical contact surface **540**.

[0053] A back leg **550** extends downwardly from proximal end **516**. Back leg **550** incorporates an upper cross-member aperture **552** that defines an upper cross-member opening **554**, and a lower cross-member aperture **556** that defines a lower cross-member opening **558**.

[0054] As shown in FIG. **11**, cross member **710** exhibits features similar to those described in relation to firedog **310** of FIG. **7**. In particular, cross member **710** includes vertical contact faces **720**, **740**, upper fingers **722**, **742**, and lower fingers **724**, **744**. Each of the fingers is configured to be received by a corresponding cross-member opening. For instance, upper cross-member opening **554** is sized, shaped, and aligned to receive upper finger **722**, and lower cross-member opening **558** is sized, shaped, and aligned to receive lower finger **724**. Additionally, cross member **710** exhibits a rectangular transverse cross-section with a height dimension at least three times longer than a width dimension. In some embodiments, the height dimension is at least four times longer than the width dimension.

[0055] FIG. **12** is a flowchart depicting an exemplary embodiment of a method for providing an andiron system. As shown in FIG. **12**, method **800** may be construed as beginning in block **802**, in which a sheet of steel plate is provided. In some embodiments, the steel plate may be carbon steel, for example. Additionally, the steel plate may be ½ inch thick in some embodiments.

[0056] In block **804**, a first firedog with a front upper finger and a front lower finger are formed as a contiguous non-weld first workpiece from the sheet of steel plate. In some embodiments, this may be accomplished by cutting the workpiece from the steel plate, such as by waterjet cutting.

[0057] In block **806**, a first front post is formed as a contiguous non-weld second workpiece. In some embodiments, the first workpiece and the second workpiece may be formed from the same sheet of steel plate.

[0058] Then, as shown in block **808**, the first workpiece and the second workpiece may be packaged together for shipping as a flat package. In some embodiments, this may involve stacking the first workpiece and the second workpiece face to face.

[0059] An exemplary embodiment of a firewood and andiron carrier (hereinafter “carrier”) that may be incorporated into an andiron system is depicted in FIG. **12**. Carrier **900** includes a body portion **902**, a first handle **904**, and a second handle **906**. Each of the body portion and handles may be formed of one or more of various materials (typically selected for their strength, durability, and/or flexibility), such as canvas and leather, for example. Body portion **900** exhibits an inside surface **908** and opposing outside surface **910**. Additionally, body portion **902** extends longitudinally between a front side **912** and a back side **914**, and transversely between a first side **916** and a second side **918**. A longitudinal axis **920** is defined along a midline of body portion **902**. Each of first handle **904** and second handle **906** is elongated, with ends of first handle **904** being attached to first side **916** and ends of second handle **906** being attached to second side **918**.

[0060] Body portion **902** also incorporates multiple pockets formed between layers of material forming the carrier. A first pocket **922** is configured to receive (at least partially) a first firedog **923**. First pocket **922** includes a first opening **924** for providing access to an interior thereof, with first opening **924** being positioned adjacent front side **912**. Stitching **926** is provided to bind overlaying layers of material forming the body portion to define the extent of first pocket **922**, and one or more mechanical fasteners (**928**) (e.g., a snap) is provided to selectively restrict the size of first opening **924**.

[0061] A second pocket **932** is configured to receive a first post **933**. Second pocket **932** includes a second opening **934** for providing access to an interior thereof, with second opening **934** extending longitudinally and being disposed between first side **916** and first pocket **922**. One or more mechanical fasteners (**936**, **938**) is provided to selectively restrict the size of second opening **934**, which may assist in retaining first post **933** within second pocket **932**.

[0062] A third pocket **942** is configured to receive (at least partially) a second firedog **943**. Third pocket **942** includes a third opening **944** for providing access to an interior thereof, with third opening **944** being positioned adjacent back side **914**. Stitching **946** is provided to bind overlaying layers of material forming the body portion to define the extent of third pocket **942**. One or more mechanical fasteners (**948**) is provided to selectively restrict the size of third opening **944**.

[0063] A fourth pocket **952** is configured to receive a second post **953**. Fourth pocket **952** includes a fourth opening **954** for providing access to an interior thereof, with fourth opening **954** extending longitudinally and being disposed between second side **918** and third pocket **942**. One or more mechanical fasteners (**956**, **958**) is provided to selectively restrict the size of fourth opening **954**, which may assist in retaining second post **953** within fourth pocket **952**.
[0064] As shown in FIG. **14**, carrier **900** may be oriented in a carry configuration, in which first handle **904** and second handle **906** are disposed adjacent to each other with body portion **902** draping downwardly therebetween. So configured, carrier **900** is suited for supporting a load upon body portion **902**, such as a load of combustible materials **960** (e.g., firewood).
[0065] As mentioned previously with respect to the exemplary method of FIG. **12**, workpieces may be packaged together for shipping as a flat package. In some embodiments, this may involve using a carrier (for example, carrier **900**) to position and stack the workpieces. By way of example, FIG. **15** schematically depicts carrier **900** in a stowed configuration that includes firedogs and posts (not shown) being disposed within corresponding pockets of carrier **900**. In the stowed configuration, carrier **900** may be disposed within a flat pack **980** for shipping. Of note, since the material layers of carrier **900** separate the firedogs and posts, use of additional packing material may be avoided, thus reducing shipping weight and/or size, which may reduce costs.
[0066] The embodiments described above are illustrative of the invention and it will be appreciated that various permutations of these embodiments may be implemented consistent with the scope and spirit of the invention as defined by the claims. Any examples provided are non-limiting examples.

Claims

1. An interlocking andiron system for use with combustible material, comprising: a first andiron assembly having a first firedog and a first front post; the first firedog having a body extending in a longitudinal direction from a proximal end to a distal end and being configured to support the combustible material in an elevated position, the first firedog exhibiting a rectangular transverse cross-section with a height dimension being at least three times longer than a width dimension, the distal end of the first firedog having a front vertical contact face; a front upper finger and a front lower finger, each extending from the front vertical contact face of the first firedog, the front upper finger having an outwardly extending front upper segment and terminating in a downwardly extending front upper tip, the front upper segment having a bottom horizontal contact surface, the front upper tip having an inwardly facing vertical contact surface, the front lower finger having an outwardly extending front lower segment and terminating in a downwardly extending front lower tip, the front lower segment having a bottom horizontal contact surface, the front lower tip having an inwardly facing vertical contact surface; the first firedog, the front upper finger, and the front lower finger being formed of contiguous material and exhibiting a planar configuration, the first front post being formed of contiguous material and exhibiting a planar configuration; the first front post having an inward face, an outward face opposing the inward face, a first upper aperture, and a first lower aperture, the first upper aperture defining a first upper opening extending through the first front post from the inward face to the outward face and being aligned to receive the front upper finger, the first lower aperture defining a first lower opening extending through the first front post from the inward face to the outward face and being aligned to receive the front lower finger, the first upper aperture having a lower horizontal contact surface, the first lower aperture having a lower horizontal contact surface; in a first assembled configuration, in which the first front post is disposed in a vertical orientation and the body of the first firedog is disposed in a horizontal orientation, the front upper finger extends through the first upper opening with the front upper tip being disposed adjacent the outward face of the first front post, the front lower finger extends through the first lower opening with the front lower tip being disposed adjacent the outward face of the first front post, the bottom horizontal contact surface of the front upper segment engages the lower horizontal contact surface of the first upper aperture, and the bottom horizontal contact surface of the front lower segment engages the lower horizontal contact surface of the first lower aperture.

2. The andiron system of claim 1, wherein an upper portion of the front vertical contact face of the first firedog extends upwardly from the front upper finger.

3. The andiron system of claim 2, wherein a lower portion of the front vertical contact face of the first firedog extends downwardly from the front lower finger.

4. The andiron system of claim 1, wherein the height dimension of the first firedog is at least four times longer than the width dimension of the rectangular transverse cross-section.

5. The andiron system of claim 1, wherein: the proximal end of the first firedog has a back vertical contact face; the first andiron assembly further comprises: a back upper finger and a back lower finger, each extending from the back vertical contact face of the first firedog, the back upper finger having an outwardly extending back upper segment and terminating in a downwardly extending back upper tip, the back upper segment having a bottom horizontal contact surface, the back upper tip having an inwardly facing vertical contact surface, the back lower finger having an outwardly extending back lower segment and terminating in a downwardly extending back lower tip, the back lower segment having a bottom horizontal contact surface, the back lower tip having an inwardly facing vertical contact surface; and a first rear post having an inward face, an outward face opposing the inward face, a first upper aperture, and a first lower aperture, the first upper aperture of the first rear post defining a first upper opening extending through the first rear post and being aligned to receive the back upper finger, the first lower aperture of the first rear post defining a first lower opening extending through the first rear post and being aligned to receive the back lower finger, the first upper aperture of the first rear post having a lower horizontal contact surface, the first lower aperture of the first rear post having a lower horizontal contact surface; in the first assembled configuration, the back upper finger extends through the first upper opening of the first rear post with the back upper tip being disposed adjacent the outward face of the first rear post, the back lower finger extends through the first lower opening of the first rear post with the back lower tip being disposed adjacent the outward face of the first rear post, the bottom horizontal contact surface of the back upper segment engages the lower horizontal contact surface of the first upper aperture of the first rear post, and the bottom horizontal contact surface of the back lower segment engages the lower horizontal contact surface of the first lower aperture of the first rear post.

6. The andiron system of claim 5, wherein: the first front post has a second upper aperture and a second lower aperture, the second upper aperture and the second lower aperture being disposed higher than the first upper aperture, the second upper aperture defining a second upper opening extending through the first front post and being aligned to receive the front upper finger, the second lower aperture defining a second lower opening extending through the first front post and being aligned to receive the front lower finger; the first rear post has a second upper aperture aligned to receive the back upper finger and a back lower aperture aligned to receive the second lower finger, the second upper aperture of the first rear post and the second lower aperture of the first rear post being disposed higher than the first upper aperture of the first rear post; and in a second assembled configuration, the front upper finger extends through the second upper opening of the first front post, the front lower finger extends through the second lower opening of the first front post, the back upper finger extends through the second upper opening of the first rear post, and the back lower finger extends through the second lower opening of the first rear post.

7. The andiron system of claim 6, further comprising a second andiron assembly having a second front post, a second rear post, and a second firedog; the second firedog extending between the second front post and the second rear post at a height corresponding to a height of the first firedog; and the first firedog and the second firedog form supports for a first horizontal cooking surface.

8. The andiron system of claim 7, further comprising a third firedog and a fourth firedog; the third firedog extending between the first front post and the first rear post at a height corresponding to the

first upper opening and the first lower opening of the first front post; the fourth firedog extending between the second front post and the second rear post at a height corresponding to a height of the third firedog; and the third firedog and the fourth firedog form supports for a second horizontal cooking surface.
9. The andiron system of claim 1, further comprising a back leg extending downwardly from the proximal end of the first firedog.
10. The andiron system of claim 9, wherein: the andiron system further comprises a second andiron assembly having: a second firedog having a body extending in a longitudinal direction from a proximal end to a distal end and being configured to support the combustible material in an elevated position, the second firedog exhibiting a rectangular transverse cross-section with a height dimension being at least three times longer than a width dimension, the distal end of the second firedog having a front vertical contact face; a front upper finger extending from the front vertical contact face of the second firedog; a front lower finger extending from the front vertical contact face of the second firedog; a back leg extending downwardly from the proximal end of the second firedog; and a second front post defining a first upper opening aligned to receive the front upper finger of the second firedog, and a first lower opening aligned to receive the front lower finger of the second firedog; in the first assembled configuration, the second front post is disposed in a vertical orientation and the body of the second firedog is disposed in a horizontal orientation, the front upper finger of the second firedog extends through the first upper opening of the second front post, and the front lower finger of the second firedog extends through the first lower opening of the second front post.
11. The andiron system of claim 10, wherein: the back leg of the first firedog defines a first cross-member opening; the back leg of the second firedog defines a second cross-member opening; the andiron system further comprises a cross member extending from a first end to a second end, the first end being configured to engage the first cross-member opening and the second end being configured to engage the second cross-member opening to maintain spacing between the first firedog and the second firedog.
12. The andiron system of claim 11, wherein the cross member is configured as a firedog having a body extending in a longitudinal direction from a proximal end to a distal end and exhibiting a rectangular transverse cross-section with a height dimension being at least three times longer than a width dimension.
13. The andiron system of claim 1, wherein the first firedog, the front upper finger, the front lower finger, and the first front post are cut from **1**/**2**″ steel plate.
14. The andiron system of claim 1, wherein: the andiron system further comprises a carrier, the carrier having a body portion, a first handle, and a second handle, the body portion extending between a front side and a back side, and between a first side and a second side, the body portion defining a first pocket and a second pocket, the first pocket configured to receive at least partially therein the first firedog, the second pocket configured to receive the first post, the first handle being elongated and having ends attached to the first side of the body portion, the second handle being elongated and having ends attached to the second side of the body portion; wherein, in a carry configuration, the first handle and the second handle are disposed adjacent to each other with the body portion extending therebetween to form a support for carrying combustible materials.
15. The andiron system of claim 14, wherein: the first pocket has a first opening providing access to an interior of the first pocket, the first opening being positioned adjacent the front side of the body portion; and the second pocket has a second opening providing access to an interior of the second pocket, the second opening being disposed between the first side of the body portion and the first pocket.
16. A method for providing an andiron system comprising: providing a sheet of steel plate; forming, as a contiguous non-weld first workpiece, a first firedog, a front upper finger, and a front lower finger from the sheet of steel plate; and forming, as a contiguous non-weld second

workpiece, a first front post; wherein: the first firedog has a body extending in a longitudinal direction from a proximal end to a distal end and being configured to support the combustible material in an elevated position, the first firedog exhibiting a rectangular transverse cross-section with a height dimension being at least three times longer than a width dimension, the distal end of the first firedog having a front vertical contact face; the front upper finger and the front lower finger each extend from the front vertical contact face of the first firedog, the front upper finger having an outwardly extending front upper segment and terminating in a downwardly extending front upper tip, the front upper segment having a bottom horizontal contact surface, the front upper tip having an inwardly facing vertical contact surface, the front lower finger having an outwardly extending front lower segment and terminating in a downwardly extending front lower tip, the front lower segment having a bottom horizontal contact surface, the front lower tip having an inwardly facing vertical contact surface; the first front post has an inward face, an outward face opposing the inward face, a first upper aperture, and a first lower aperture, the first upper aperture defining a first upper opening extending through the first front post from the inward face to the outward face and being aligned to receive the front upper finger, the first lower aperture defining a first lower opening extending through the first front post from the inward face to the outward face and being aligned to receive the front lower finger, the first upper aperture having a lower horizontal contact surface, the first lower aperture having a lower horizontal contact surface; in a first assembled configuration, in which the first front post is disposed in a vertical orientation and the body of the first firedog is disposed in a horizontal orientation, the front upper finger extends through the first upper opening with the front upper tip being disposed adjacent the outward face of the first front post, the front lower finger extends through the first lower opening with the front lower tip being disposed adjacent the outward face of the first front post, the bottom horizontal contact surface of the front upper segment engages the lower horizontal contact surface of the first upper aperture, and the bottom horizontal contact surface of the front lower segment engages the lower horizontal contact surface of the first lower aperture.
17. The method of claim 16, wherein the forming of the first workpiece comprises waterjet cutting of the steel plate.
18. The method of claim 16, further comprising packing the first workpiece and the second workpiece together for shipping as a flat package.
19. The method of claim 18, wherein the packing comprises stacking the first workpiece and the second workpiece face to face.
20. The method of claim 18, wherein the packing further comprises: providing a carrier having a body portion, a first handle, and a second handle, the body portion extending between a front side and a back side, and between a first side and a second side, the body portion defining a first pocket and a second pocket, the first pocket configured to receive at least partially therein the first firedog, the second pocket configured to receive the first post, the first handle being elongated and having ends attached to the first side of the body, the second handle being elongated and having ends attached to the second side of the body; and inserting the first firedog at least partially within the first pocket and the first post within the second pocket.